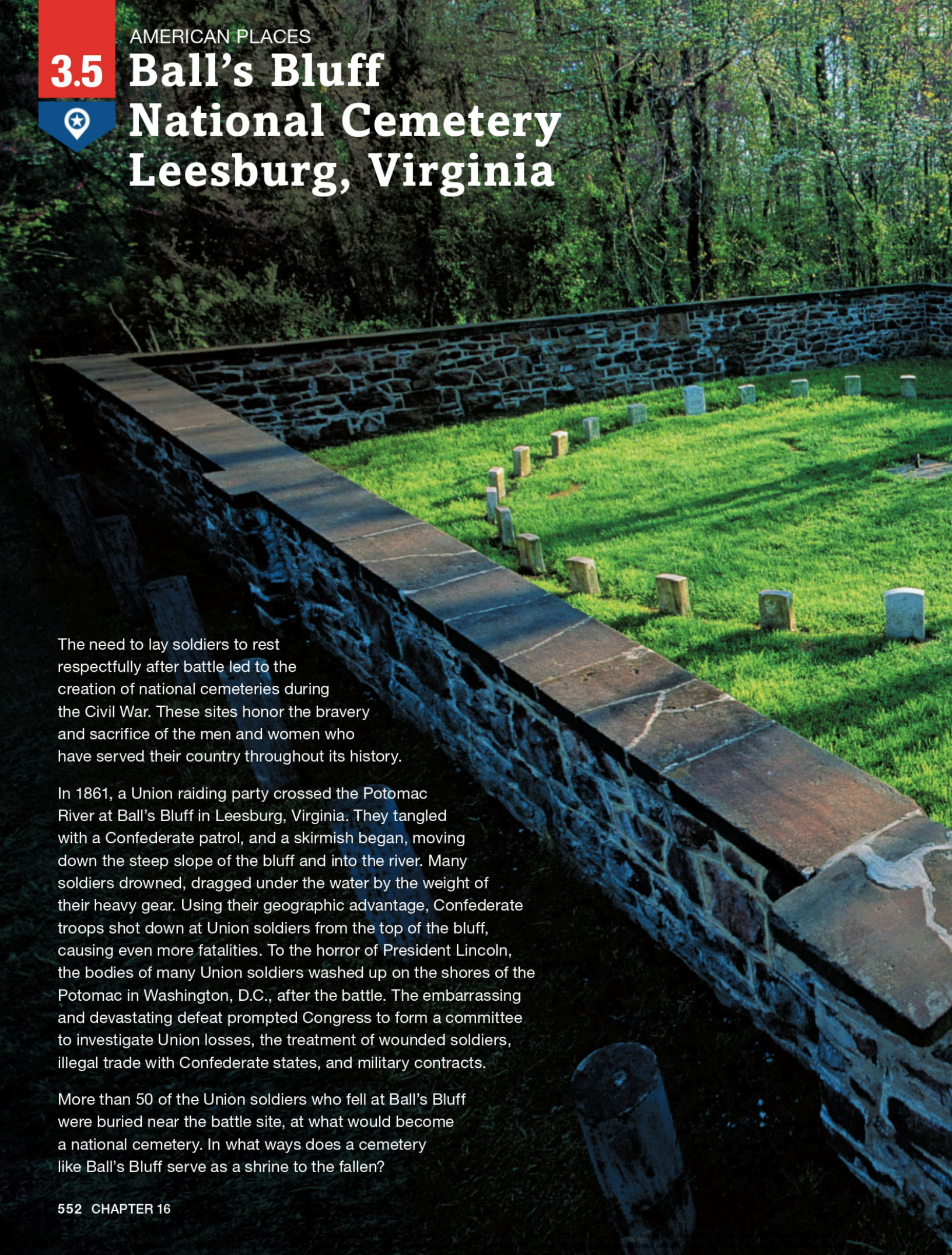
AMERICAN PLACES

3.5

Ball's Bluff National Cemetery Leesburg, Virginia



The need to lay soldiers to rest respectfully after battle led to the creation of national cemeteries during the Civil War. These sites honor the bravery and sacrifice of the men and women who have served their country throughout its history.

In 1861, a Union raiding party crossed the Potomac River at Ball's Bluff in Leesburg, Virginia. They tangled with a Confederate patrol, and a skirmish began, moving down the steep slope of the bluff and into the river. Many soldiers drowned, dragged under the water by the weight of their heavy gear. Using their geographic advantage, Confederate troops shot down at Union soldiers from the top of the bluff, causing even more fatalities. To the horror of President Lincoln, the bodies of many Union soldiers washed up on the shores of the Potomac in Washington, D.C., after the battle. The embarrassing and devastating defeat prompted Congress to form a committee to investigate Union losses, the treatment of wounded soldiers, illegal trade with Confederate states, and military contracts.

More than 50 of the Union soldiers who fell at Ball's Bluff were buried near the battle site, at what would become a national cemetery. In what ways does a cemetery like Ball's Bluff serve as a shrine to the fallen?



CRITICAL VIEWING The Ball's Bluff National Cemetery is one of the nation's smallest military cemeteries. Established in 1865 as the burial place for Union soldiers killed at Ball's Bluff, only the name of one soldier is known: James Allen, a Union soldier and member of Company H, 15th Massachusetts Infantry. What does the unique perspective of this photo by National Geographic photographer Ken Garrett reveal about the cemetery?

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